VENVLEARNING

STUDENT TEXTBOOK



Social Studies

GRADE 7

Lessons, examples, and practice for the whole year

2 units

VENVLEARNING

Grade 7 Social Studies

STUDENT TEXTBOOK

Unit 1 Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Unit 2 River Valley Civilizations

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

How to use this book

Every lesson starts on a new page with the same parts, so you always know where to look. Read the Look Closer boxes to see how a historian or geographer reads a source, map, or chart, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions. Your practice pages are in your Student Workbook, labeled with the same lesson number.

- Today's Goal (the box with the target) says what you will be able to do by the end of the lesson.
- Today's Assignment is your checklist for the day. Tick each box as you finish it.
- Each lesson page has three panels. The wide center panel is the lesson, in numbered steps: 1 Get Ready, 2 Learn, and 3 Check Your Understanding.
- The left panel holds things to remember: Key Ideas (the most important rule or fact; learn these), Watch Out warnings about common mistakes, tips, and a Remember note that sums up the lesson. Each one sits beside the part of the lesson it goes with.
- The right panel holds Words to Know (definitions), what to read in your Reader, and other extras.
- Pages that look like a page from a book, on cream paper with a brown READING tab, are things to read: stories, excerpts, and articles.
- Activity boxes are hands-on map, source, and timeline work. Do them with your teacher.
- At the end of each week of lessons there is a short Weekly Check in your workbook. Each unit ends with the Unit Test.

Contents

Early Humans and Mesopotamia 4

Lesson 1.1: How Historians Know the Past 6

Lesson 1.2: Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers 9

Lesson 1.3: The Agricultural Revolution 11

Lesson 1.4: From Villages to Civilizations 14

Lesson 1.5: Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers 16

Lesson 1.6: Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society 19

Lesson 1.7: Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing 21

Lesson 1.8: Empires and the Code of Hammurabi 24

Unit 1 Study Guide 27

River Valley Civilizations 28

Lesson 2.1: Egypt: Gift of the Nile 30

Lesson 2.2: Pharaohs, Pyramids, and the Afterlife 33

Lesson 2.3: Egypt and Kush: Trade and Power 36

Lesson 2.4: The Indus Valley Civilization 39

Lesson 2.5: Hinduism, Buddhism, and the Maurya Empire 42

Lesson 2.6: China: The Huang He and the Shang Dynasty 45

Lesson 2.7: Zhou, Qin, and Han: Confucius, the Great Wall, and the Silk Road 48

Lesson 2.8: Comparing River Valley Civilizations 51

Unit 2 Study Guide 54

Glossary 55

UNIT 1

Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Historians' tools, early humans, the Agricultural Revolution, the first cities, Sumer, writing, and the first empires and laws.

Ten thousand years ago, nearly everyone on Earth lived by hunting and gathering. Then, in a few river valleys, people began to farm, settle, and build cities. In this unit you'll learn how historians uncover the distant past, then follow humans from the Old Stone Age to Sumer, where people built the first cities, invented writing, and carved laws in stone.

In this unit you will...

- Use primary and secondary sources and read BCE/CE timelines.
- Explain how the Agricultural Revolution changed human life.
- Analyze how Mesopotamia's geography shaped civilization.
- Describe Sumerian society, writing, and the first empires and laws.

CONNECTIONS TODAY

Writing, cities, and written law all began in Mesopotamia. Every time you read a contract, check the time, or follow a posted rule, you're using ideas over 4,000 years old.

UNIT VOCABULARY

primary source	Created at the time by a participant.
Agricultural Revolution	The shift to farming.
civilization	A complex society with cities and government.
irrigation	Bringing water to crops.
cuneiform	Sumerian wedge-shaped writing.
empire	Many lands under one ruler.

Lessons in this unit

Lesson	Title
1.1	How Historians Know the Past
1.2	Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers
1.3	The Agricultural Revolution
1.4	From Villages to Civilizations
1.5	Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers
1.6	Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society
1.7	Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing
1.8	Empires and the Code of Hammurabi

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.1
Week 1 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.1: How Historians Know the Past

TODAY'S GOAL

I can distinguish primary and secondary sources, explain how archaeologists learn about the past, and read a BCE/CE timeline.

Standards: C3 D2.His.9.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.1 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Time Capsule Detectives.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.1, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.1 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Imagine someone in 5,000 years digs up your bedroom. What would your things tell them about you, and what would they get wrong?

2 Learn

Historians are detectives. They gather evidence from primary sources (letters, laws, inscriptions, photographs,

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

primary source
A source created by someone who was there at the time.

secondary source
A source created later by someone studying the past.

artifact
An object made or used by people in the past.

archaeologist
A scientist who studies the past by digging up and examining artifacts and remains.

BCE / CE
"Before the Common Era" and "Common Era": the years before and after year 1.

REMEMBER

artifacts) and secondary sources (textbooks, articles, documentaries). For times before writing, archaeologists study artifacts, bones, seeds, and buildings. Scientists can estimate the age of once-living material using radiocarbon dating.

Every source has limits. A king's inscription may brag. Artifacts made of stone and clay survive, but cloth, wood, and memories usually don't. Good historians ask: Who made this? When? Why? What might be missing?

Dates before year 1 are written BCE and count down toward year 1: 3000 BCE is earlier than 2000 BCE. Dates after are CE and count up. There is no year 0.



LOOK CLOSER · COUNT ACROSS THE BCE/CE LINE

How many years passed between 500 BCE and 500 CE?

1 From 500 BCE to 1 BCE is 499 years; then 1 BCE to 1 CE is 1 year.

2 From 1 CE to 500 CE is 499 years.

3 499 + 1 + 499 = 999.

Answer: 999 years (because there is no year 0).

KEY IDEA

Historians use primary and secondary sources, ask who made a source and why, and recognize that evidence is always incomplete.

ACTIVITY · TIME CAPSULE DETECTIVES

What can objects tell us, and what can't they?

You need: a box of 6–8 everyday objects chosen by your teacher (receipt, toy, coin, photo, tool, food wrapper).

1 Examine each object as if you were an archaeologist in the year 7026.

2 For each, write one inference about the people who used it.

3 Sort the objects into primary sources and secondary sources (if any).

4 Write what these objects can't tell you about the family.

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

✓ REMEMBER

Historians use primary and secondary sources; BCE counts down, CE counts up.

Record: an evidence chart: Object | What it suggests | Questions it raises.

WORDS & MORE

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Write primary or secondary for each source, or answer the question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.1, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Primary or secondary: a clay tablet written in 2000 BCE
2. Primary or secondary: a website about ancient Sumer
3. Which is earlier, 2500 BCE or 1800 BCE?

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.2
Week 1 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.2: Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe how early humans lived as hunter-gatherers and spread across the world.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Geo.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.2 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: What's in the Pack?.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.2, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.2 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

If you had no stores, farms, or metal tools, how would you get food and stay warm?

2 Learn

Fossils show that our species, Homo sapiens, appeared in Africa roughly 300,000 years ago. Over many thousands of years, groups migrated out of Africa into Asia, Europe, Australia, and eventually the Americas.

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

hunter-gatherer
A person who gets food by hunting animals and gathering wild plants.

nomad
A person who moves from place to place instead of living in one settlement.

Paleolithic
The Old Stone Age, when people made stone tools and lived as hunter-gatherers.

migration
Movement of people from one place to another.

REMEMBER

For almost all of human history, people lived as hunter-gatherers during the Paleolithic, or Old Stone Age. Small groups of related families moved with the seasons, following herds and ripening plants. They made tools of stone, bone, and wood, used fire to cook and stay warm, made clothing from hides, and painted animals on cave walls, such as the famous paintings at Lascaux, France, made about 17,000 years ago.

Need	How hunter-gatherers met it
food	hunting, fishing, gathering nuts, roots, berries
shelter	caves, huts of branches, bones, and hides
tools	stone blades and scrapers, spears, needles of bone
communication and art	spoken language, cave paintings, carvings, music

WORDS & MORE

KEY IDEA

For most of human history, people were nomadic hunter-gatherers who used stone tools and fire and spread from Africa across the world.

ACTIVITY · WHAT'S IN THE PACK?

What would a nomadic family carry?

You need: paper; pencil.

1. Your band of 25 is moving to its winter camp. Everything must be carried.
2. List the 8 most important items you would take and why.
3. Compare your list with a family member's and agree on a final list.

Record: your final list with a reason for each item.

✓ REMEMBER

Early humans were nomadic hunter-gatherers who spread out of Africa.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.2, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Where did Homo sapiens first appear?
2. Why did hunter-gatherers move often?
3. Name one Paleolithic technology.

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.3
Week 2 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.3: The Agricultural Revolution

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how farming began and how it changed human life.

Standards: C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.3 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Gains and Losses.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.3, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.3 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Would you rather move every season to find food, or stay in one place and grow it? What would you gain and lose?

2 Learn

Beginning around 10,000 BCE in the Fertile Crescent of Southwest Asia, people began planting wild wheat and barley and herding goats and sheep. This change, called the Agricultural Revolution, took thousands of years. Farming also began on its own in other places: rice and millet in

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

domestication
Taming plants and animals so they can be raised by people.

Neolithic
The New Stone Age, when farming began.

surplus
More than is needed to survive.

Agricultural Revolution
The shift from hunting and gathering to farming.

REMEMBER

China, corn in Mexico, potatoes in South America.

WORDS & MORE

Early farming villages in the Fertile Crescent



Before farming	After farming
nomadic	settled villages
small bands	larger populations
food found or hunted	food grown and stored; surplus
few possessions	houses, pottery, tools for farming
most people did the same work	some people specialized in other jobs

Farming brought problems too. People worked long hours, ate fewer kinds of food, and could starve if crops failed. Living close together and near animals spread disease. Still, food surplus allowed populations to grow and set the stage for cities.

KEY IDEA

Domesticating plants and animals let people settle, grow surpluses, and build larger communities, with new benefits and new problems.

ACTIVITY · GAINS AND LOSSES

Was farming an improvement?

You need: paper.

1 Make a T-chart: Gains | Losses.

2 List at least four of each from the lesson.

3 Decide: for an ordinary person, was life better or worse? Write a claim with two pieces of evidence.

Record: your T-chart and claim.

REMEMBER

✓ REMEMBER

Farming let people settle and grow surpluses, changing human life.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.3, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Where did farming first begin?
2. What is a surplus?
3. Name one problem farming created.

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.4
Week 2 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.4: From Villages to Civilizations

TODAY'S GOAL

I can identify the features of a civilization and explain how surplus led to cities.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.4 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Village to City Simulation.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.4, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.4 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

What makes a city different from a village?

2 Learn

Some farming villages grew into towns. Jericho, near the Jordan River, had a stone wall and tower by about 8000 BCE. Çatalhöyük in Anatolia (modern Turkey) was home to thousands of people around 7000 BCE; its houses were built so close together that people walked across the rooftops and entered through openings in the roofs.

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

civilization
A complex society with cities, government, specialized jobs, social classes, and record keeping.

specialization
Doing one kind of job and trading for other needs.

social class
A group of people with similar wealth or status.

REMEMBER

Historians use several features to describe a civilization:

Feature	Why it appears
cities	food surplus supports many people in one place
organized government	leaders manage water, defense, and laws
specialized jobs	potters, weavers, priests, soldiers, traders
social classes	some people gain more wealth or power
religion and public buildings	temples unite people around shared beliefs
writing and record keeping	track harvests, taxes, and trade
technology and art	new tools, buildings, and crafts



KEY IDEA

Food surplus led to larger populations, specialized jobs, and the features of civilization.

ACTIVITY · VILLAGE TO CITY SIMULATION

How does a surplus change a community?

You need: 20 dried beans (grain); role cards: farmer, potter, priest, guard, trader.

1. Each farmer 'grows' 5 beans per season but needs only 3 to eat.
2. Decide how the 2 extra beans per farmer can support people with other jobs.
3. Add one more job each round as the surplus grows.

Record: how many non-farmers your surplus could support, and the new problems (who decides? who guards the beans?).

✓ REMEMBER

Surplus → population → specialization → cities and government.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.4, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Name three features of a civilization.
2. What made specialization possible?
3. How did people enter houses at Çatalhöyük?

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.5
Week 3 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.5: Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how the geography of Mesopotamia shaped early civilization there.

Standards: C3 D2.Geo.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.5 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Irrigation Model.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.5, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.5 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Mesopotamia had hot, dry summers and almost no rain in the south, yet it became home to the world's first cities. How?

2 Learn

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

Mesopotamia
Greek for "land between the rivers"; the region between the Tigris and Euphrates.

irrigation
Bringing water to crops through canals or ditches.

silt
Fine, rich soil carried and left behind by rivers.

levee
A raised bank that keeps a river from flooding.

REMEMBER

The Fertile Crescent



Mesopotamia lies between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers in modern Iraq. Each spring, snow melting in the northern mountains made the rivers flood, spreading rich silt over the plain. But the floods were unpredictable: some years they were too small, other years they destroyed fields and villages. Summers were hot and rainfall was low.

Farmers solved these problems by working together. They dug irrigation canals to carry river water to fields, built levees to hold back floods, and stored water for dry months. Organizing these big projects required leaders and laws. The region had few trees and little stone, so people built with sun-dried mud bricks and traded grain and cloth for wood, stone, and metal.

Geographic challenge	Human solution
unpredictable floods	levees and drainage ditches
little rain in summer	irrigation canals and storage basins
few trees or stone	mud bricks; trade for resources
flat land, open to invaders	city walls and armies

KEY IDEA

Mesopotamia's rivers gave rich soil and water, but floods and dry summers forced people to cooperate on irrigation and levees.

ACTIVITY · IRRIGATION MODEL

How can canals bring water to fields?

You need: a baking pan with soil or sand; a cup of water; a craft stick.

1 Shape a “river” along one side of the pan.

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

2 Use the stick to carve canals from the river to three “fields.”

3 Pour water into the river at the high end. Where does it go?

4 Add a small dirt bank (levee) and test it again.

Record: a labeled sketch of your irrigation system and what worked.

WORDS & MORE

✓ REMEMBER

Rivers gave Mesopotamia rich soil, but floods and drought required irrigation and cooperation.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.5, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What does “Mesopotamia” mean?
2. Name the two rivers.
3. Why did Mesopotamians build with mud brick?

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.6
Week 3 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.6: Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe Sumerian city-states, religion, and social classes.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Civ.6.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.6 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Design a Ziggurat.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.6, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.6 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

If your town had its own king, army, and gods, how would you feel about the next town over?

2 Learn

By about 3500 BCE, the people of Sumer, in southern Mesopotamia, had built some of the world's first cities, including Ur and Uruk. Each was a city-state with its own ruler, army, and patron god. City-states often fought over water and land.

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

city-state
A city and the farmland around it with its own government.

ziggurat
A large stepped temple tower in a Sumerian city.

polytheism
Belief in many gods.

scribe
A person trained to read and write and keep records.

REMEMBER

Sumerians practiced polytheism. They believed gods controlled nature and that people must serve them. At the center of each city stood a ziggurat, a huge stepped tower of mud brick with a temple on top. Priests were powerful, and at first they helped manage the city's grain. Over time, war leaders became kings, who claimed to rule with the gods' approval.

Social class	Who
upper class	kings, priests, and nobles
middle class	merchants, artisans, scribes, farmers who owned land
lower class	farm workers and laborers
enslaved people	often prisoners of war or people in debt

Women in Sumer could own property and run businesses, and some were priestesses, but most power belonged to men.

WORDS & MORE

KEY IDEA

Sumer was made of independent city-states centered on ziggurats, ruled by kings and priests, with clear social classes.

ACTIVITY · DESIGN A ZIGGURAT

What did a ziggurat show about Sumerian values?

You need: sugar cubes or building blocks; paper.

1. Build a three-level stepped tower with a shrine on top.
2. Add a ramp or stairway.
3. Write two sentences explaining why the temple was the tallest building in the city.

Record: a sketch and your explanation.

✓ REMEMBER

Sumer's city-states centered on ziggurats with kings, priests, and social classes.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.6, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Name two Sumerian city-states.
2. What was a ziggurat?
3. Why did city-states fight?

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.7
Week 4 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.7: Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how and why writing developed in Sumer and how it changed society.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.7 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Clay Tablet Scribe.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.7, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.7 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

How would your life change if nothing could be written down?

2 Learn

Around 3200 BCE, Sumerians in cities like Uruk began keeping records on clay tablets. At first they drew small pictures to count grain, sheep, and taxes. Over time the pictures became wedge-shaped marks pressed with a reed stylus: cuneiform, from the Latin word for “wedge.”

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

cuneiform
Sumerian writing made of wedge-shaped marks pressed into clay.

stylus
A pointed tool used to write on clay.

epic
A long poem about a hero's deeds.

REMEMBER

Cuneiform was used for more than 3,000 years and for many languages.

Writing was hard to learn, so scribes trained for years in schools. They wrote contracts, laws, letters, medical texts, prayers, and literature, including the Epic of Gilgamesh, one of the oldest stories in the world. It tells of Gilgamesh, a king of Uruk, who searches for the secret of living forever and learns that every human life must end.



Other Sumerian innovations include the wheel (used for pottery and carts), the plow, sailboats, and a number system based on 60, which is why we still have 60 minutes in an hour and 360 degrees in a circle.

KEY IDEA

Writing began as record keeping, became cuneiform, and let people keep laws, history, and literature.

ACTIVITY · CLAY TABLET SCRIBE

What was it like to write in cuneiform?

You need: air-dry clay or play dough; a craft stick cut to a wedge point or a chopstick.

1. Flatten the clay into a tablet.
2. Press wedge shapes to record a “receipt”: 5 sheep and 3 jars of barley (invent symbols).
3. Trade tablets with a partner and try to read each other's record.

Record: your symbol key and two problems a scribe would face.

✓ REMEMBER

Cuneiform began as record keeping and grew into laws and literature.

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

WORDS & MORE

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.7, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What was cuneiform first used for?
2. What does cuneiform mean?
3. Who was Gilgamesh?

REMEMBER

LESSON 1.8
Week 4 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.8: Empires and the Code of Hammurabi

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe the first empires and analyze Hammurabi's Code as a primary source.

Standards: C3 D2.Civ.3.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 1.8 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Fair or Unfair?.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.8, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.8 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Why might it matter that laws are written down for everyone to see?

2 Learn

Around 2334 BCE, Sargon of Akkad conquered the Sumerian city-states and created what many historians call the world's first empire. Later, Hammurabi, king of Babylon (ruled about 1792–1750 BCE), united much of Mesopotamia. About 1754 BCE he had 282 laws carved on a tall stone stele

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

empire
Many lands and peoples ruled by one government.

code of law
A written set of laws.

stele
A tall carved stone slab.

REMEMBER

for public display. The stele is now in the Louvre museum in Paris.

WORDS & MORE

READING · PRIMARY SOURCE

From the Code of Hammurabi

Babylon, about 1754 BCE. Translated by L. W. King (1910). Public domain.

196. If a man put out the eye of another man, his eye shall be put out.

198. If he put out the eye of a freed man, or break the bone of a freed man, he shall pay one gold mina.

199. If he put out the eye of a man's slave, or break the bone of a man's slave, he shall pay one-half of its value.

229. If a builder build a house for some one, and does not construct it properly, and the house which he built fall in and kill its owner, then that builder shall be put to death.

LOOK CLOSER · ANALYZE A PRIMARY SOURCE

What do Laws 196, 198, and 199 reveal about Babylonian society?

1. Law 196: harming another man means the same harm in return (“an eye for an eye”).
2. Law 198: harming a freed man means paying a fine (one gold mina) instead.
3. Law 199: harming an enslaved person means paying the owner.

Answer: Punishments depended on social class, so Babylonian law treated people unequally; laws protected property and order more than equal rights.

REMEMBER

Hammurabi's Code was not the first law code, but it is one of the best preserved. By writing laws in public, he showed that rules applied across his empire, and he claimed the gods gave him authority to rule justly.

WORDS & MORE

KEY IDEA

Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi's written code brought order but punished people differently by class.

ACTIVITY · FAIR OR UNFAIR?

Do these laws match our ideas of justice?

You need: the source excerpt; highlighters.

1. Highlight each punishment.
2. Rate each law from 1 (very unfair) to 5 (very fair) by today's standards.
3. Find one idea in the code that is similar to modern law (for example, builders responsible for safe buildings).

Record: your ratings and a paragraph comparing Hammurabi's Code with modern laws.

✓ REMEMBER

Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi wrote laws for all to see.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.8, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Who created the first empire?
2. About when was Hammurabi's Code written?
3. Did the code treat all people equally?

UNIT 1 REVIEW

Unit 1 Study Guide

Use this page to get ready for the unit test. Read each big idea, then try the review pages in your workbook.

Lesson	Remember…
1.1	Historians use primary and secondary sources; BCE counts down, CE counts up.
1.2	Early humans were nomadic hunter-gatherers who spread out of Africa.
1.3	Farming let people settle and grow surpluses, changing human life.
1.4	Surplus → population → specialization → cities and government.
1.5	Rivers gave Mesopotamia rich soil, but floods and drought required irrigation and cooperation.
1.6	Sumer's city-states centered on ziggurats with kings, priests, and social classes.
1.7	Cuneiform began as record keeping and grew into laws and literature.
1.8	Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi wrote laws for all to see.

UNIT 2

River Valley Civilizations

Ancient Egypt and Kush, the Indus Valley, Hinduism and Buddhism, and ancient China from the Shang to the Han.

Mesopotamia was not the only place where people built cities beside a river. In this unit you'll travel up the Nile to the pyramids of Egypt and Kush, walk the planned streets of the Indus Valley, learn the beliefs that shaped India, and follow China from oracle bones to the Great Wall and the Silk Road. Then you'll compare the first civilizations and decide what each one left the world.

In this unit you will...

- Explain how rivers shaped Egypt, the Indus Valley, and China.
- Describe Egyptian and Kushite government, beliefs, and trade.
- Explain the main beliefs of Hinduism and Buddhism.
- Explain China's dynasties, the Mandate of Heaven, and Confucian ideas.
- Compare the four river valley civilizations.

CONNECTIONS TODAY

Engineers who design flood control, city planners who lay out streets and sewers, and diplomats who study other cultures all build on lessons from the first river valley civilizations.

UNIT VOCABULARY

silt	Rich soil left by water.
pharaoh	Egypt's ruler, seen as a god.
cultural diffusion	The spread of ideas.
karma	Actions decide the future.
dynasty	Rulers from one family.
Mandate of Heaven	Heaven's approval to rule.

Lessons in this unit

Lesson	Title
2.1	Egypt: Gift of the Nile
2.2	Pharaohs, Pyramids, and the Afterlife
2.3	Egypt and Kush: Trade and Power
2.4	The Indus Valley Civilization
2.5	Hinduism, Buddhism, and the Maurya Empire
2.6	China: The Huang He and the Shang Dynasty
2.7	Zhou, Qin, and Han: Confucius, the Great Wall, and the Silk Road
2.8	Comparing River Valley Civilizations

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.1
Week 1 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.1: Egypt: Gift of the Nile

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how the Nile River shaped where and how ancient Egyptians lived.

Standards: C3 D2.Geo.4.6-8, D2.His.1.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.1 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Flood Model.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.1, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.1 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Egypt gets almost no rain, yet it fed millions of people for thousands of years. How is that possible?

2 Learn

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

delta
The flat, fan-shaped land where a river splits and flows into the sea.

silt
Fine, rich soil carried and left behind by water.

inundation
The yearly flood of the Nile.

cataract
A stretch of rocky rapids in a river.

unify
To bring together into one.

REMEMBER

The Greek writer Herodotus called Egypt “the gift of the Nile.” The Nile is the world's longest river, about 4,100 miles. Unlike most rivers, it flows north, from the mountains of East Africa to the Mediterranean Sea.

Almost all Egyptians lived on a narrow green strip along the river. Beyond it lay the Sahara, the “red land” of desert that also protected Egypt from invaders.

Because the Nile flows north, Upper Egypt is in the south and Lower Egypt is in the north, around the delta.



WORDS & MORE

Every summer, rains far to the south made the Nile rise. During the inundation, the river spread over its banks. When the water went down in the fall, it left a layer of black silt, and farmers planted wheat, barley, and flax in the “black land.” Farmers used a shaduf, a bucket on a pole, to lift water into irrigation canals. Rocky rapids called cataracts to the south made boat travel difficult there.

Feature of the Nile	How it helped Egyptians
yearly flood and silt	rich soil for crops and a food surplus
flows north; winds blow south	boats could float north and sail south: easy trade
papyrus reeds along the banks	paper, rope, sandals, and boats
deserts on both sides	natural protection from invaders

KEY IDEA

The Nile's yearly flood left rich silt for farming, its current and winds made trade easy, and the deserts protected Egypt. Egypt was unified around 3100 BCE.

Around 3100 BCE, a king of Upper Egypt, traditionally called Narmer or Menes, unified Upper and Lower Egypt into one kingdom. Egyptian history is divided into the Old, Middle, and New Kingdoms, with more than 30 ruling families, or dynasties, over about 3,000 years.

REMEMBER

WATCH OUT

On maps, “Upper” Egypt is at the bottom and “Lower” Egypt is at the top. The names come from the river's flow: upriver is south.

✓ REMEMBER

The Nile's flood, current, and deserts made Egypt rich, connected, and safe.

ACTIVITY · FLOOD MODEL

How did the inundation make farmland?

You need: a long pan or tray; soil; a cup of muddy water; a spoon.

1. Spread dry soil in the tray and press a groove for the river.
2. Slowly pour the muddy water down the groove until it spills over the banks.
3. Let it sit, then pour off the extra water.
4. Look at what is left on the “fields.”

Record: a labeled sketch and two sentences explaining how flood silt helped Egyptian farmers.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.1, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. In which direction does the Nile flow?
2. What did the inundation leave behind?
3. Why is Upper Egypt in the south?

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.2
Week 1 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.2: Pharaohs, Pyramids, and the Afterlife

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how Egyptian beliefs about pharaohs and the afterlife shaped their government, art, and buildings.

Standards: C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Civ.6.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.2 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Cartouche.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.2, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.2 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Why would people spend 20 years building one tomb?

2 Learn

Egyptians believed their king, the pharaoh, was a god on Earth who kept ma'at: order, truth, and balance. Because the ruler was divine, Egypt was a theocracy. The pharaoh owned all the land, led the army, and ran the government

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

pharaoh
The ruler of ancient Egypt, believed to be a god on Earth.

theocracy
A government ruled by religious leaders or a ruler seen as divine.

mummy
A body preserved so it will last a long time.

hieroglyphics
Egyptian writing that used pictures and symbols.

afterlife
Life after death.

REMEMBER

through officials called viziers and scribes.

Egyptians were polytheists who worshiped many gods, such as Ra, the sun god, and Osiris, god of the afterlife. They believed the dead needed their bodies in the next life, so priests made mummies, a 70-day process of drying and wrapping the body. Tombs held food, furniture, and treasures for the journey.

Old Kingdom pharaohs built pyramids as tombs. The Great Pyramid at Giza, built for the pharaoh Khufu around 2560 BCE, used more than two million stone blocks. Archaeologists have found that it was built by paid, skilled workers and farm laborers during the flood season, not by enslaved armies. Later pharaohs were buried in hidden tombs in the Valley of the Kings, such as the tomb of Tutankhamun, found in 1922.

Egyptians wrote with hieroglyphics, more than 700 picture symbols, on stone and papyrus. For centuries no one could read them. Then, in 1799, French soldiers found the Rosetta Stone, carved with the same message in hieroglyphics, a later Egyptian script, and Greek. In 1822, Jean-François Champollion used the Greek to decode the hieroglyphs.

WORDS & MORE

LOOK CLOSER · USE EVIDENCE TO MAKE AN INFERENCE

Tombs were filled with bread, jars of beer, furniture, games, and small statues of servants.

1 Evidence: the objects are things people use in daily life.

2 Background: Egyptians believed in an afterlife.

3 Inference: they expected the dead to need these things in the next life.

Answer: Tomb goods show that Egyptians believed the afterlife was much like life on Earth.

ACTIVITY · CARTOUCHE

How did hieroglyphs represent sounds?

You need: paper; pencil and markers; a hieroglyph alphabet chart (print one from a museum website).

KEY IDEA

Egyptians saw the pharaoh as a god, so religion and government were joined. Belief in the afterlife led to mummies, tomb goods, and pyramids. The Rosetta Stone unlocked hieroglyphics.

REMEMBER

1. Draw a long oval with a line at one end: a cartouche, which held a pharaoh's name.
2. Spell your name with the hieroglyph sound chart, from top to bottom.
3. Decorate the border.
4. Trade with a family member and have them decode it.

Record: your cartouche and one sentence explaining why the Rosetta Stone mattered.

WORDS & MORE

✓ REMEMBER

Egyptians believed the pharaoh was divine and planned for the afterlife with mummies and pyramids.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.2, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Why was Egypt a theocracy?
2. Why did Egyptians make mummies?
3. How did the Rosetta Stone help scholars read hieroglyphics?

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.3
Week 2 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.3: Egypt and Kush: Trade and Power

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe how Egypt and Kush influenced each other through trade, conquest, and culture.

Standards: C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Eco.15.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.3 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Trade Map.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.3, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.3 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Two neighbors trade, fight, and borrow ideas from each other for 2,000 years. How might each one change?

2 Learn

South of Egypt, past the cataracts, lay Nubia, home of the kingdom of Kush. Nubia was rich in gold, ebony wood, ivory, and incense. Egypt traded with Kush, and at times New Kingdom pharaohs conquered it. Kushites adopted

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

Nubia
The region along the Nile south of Egypt, in today's Sudan.

Kush
A powerful African kingdom in Nubia.

cultural diffusion
The spread of ideas and customs from one group to another.

export
A good sent to another place to be sold.

REMEMBER

Egyptian gods, writing, and pyramid tombs: this is cultural diffusion.

Egyptian trade reached far. The female pharaoh Hatshepsut (ruled about 1479–1458 BCE) sent a famous trading expedition to the land of Punt, returning with incense trees, gold, and animals. Ramses II (ruled about 1279–1213 BCE) expanded Egypt's power with wars and huge monuments.

Then the tables turned. Around 750 BCE, the Kushite king Piye conquered Egypt, and Kushite kings ruled as pharaohs for nearly a century. Later, Kush moved its capital south to Meroë, which became a center of iron-making and trade. Meroë's kings built more than 200 steep pyramids, more than in all of Egypt.

WORDS & MORE

	Egypt	Kush
location	lower Nile, north of the cataracts	upper Nile, in Nubia
exports	grain, linen, papyrus	gold, ivory, ebony, iron, incense
capital cities	Memphis, Thebes	Napata, then Meroë
shared culture	gods, pyramids, hieroglyphs	adopted Egyptian gods, pyramids, and writing; later its own Meroitic script

KEY IDEA

Egypt and Kush traded, fought, and shared ideas for centuries. Kush adopted Egyptian ways, conquered Egypt around 750 BCE, and later thrived at Meroë as an iron-making center.

ACTIVITY · TRADE MAP

What moved between Egypt and Kush?

You need: a copy of the Nile Valley map; colored pencils.

1. Trace the Nile from Meroë to the delta.
2. Draw arrows for goods moving north (from Kush) and south (from Egypt), using the chart.
3. Label each arrow with two goods.
4. Add a symbol for one idea that spread by cultural diffusion.

Record: your labeled trade map.

✓ REMEMBER

Egypt and Kush traded, fought, and shared culture; Kush later ruled Egypt and thrived at Meroë.

REMEMBER

WORDS & MORE

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.3, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Name two goods Kush traded.
2. Which Kushite king conquered Egypt around 750 BCE?
3. Give an example of cultural diffusion between Egypt and Kush.

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.4
Week 2 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.4: The Indus Valley Civilization

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe the planned cities of the Indus Valley and explain what archaeologists still don't know about them.

Standards: C3 D2.His.10.6-8, D2.Geo.2.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.4 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Plan a City.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.4, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.4 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

What would a city need to keep 40,000 people healthy and clean, without any electricity?

2 Learn

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

subcontinent
A large landmass that is part of a continent, such as India.

monsoon
A seasonal wind that brings heavy rain.

citadel
A fortress or raised area in a city.

standardized
Made the same everywhere, such as weights or bricks.

REMEMBER

WORDS & MORE

The Indus and Ganges valleys



The Indus and Ganges rivers flow from the Himalayas.

Around 2600 BCE, a civilization grew along the Indus River in what is now Pakistan and northwestern India. Snow melting from the Himalayas and summer monsoon rains flooded the river and left rich silt, like the Nile. Its largest cities, Harappa and Mohenjo-daro, may each have held tens of thousands of people.

Indus cities were carefully planned. Streets ran in straight lines in a grid. Houses were built of baked bricks of the same size. Many homes had bathrooms, and covered drains carried waste away under the streets, a system more advanced than many cities had thousands of years later. A raised citadel held large buildings, such as the Great Bath at Mohenjo-daro. Traders used standardized stone weights and carved seals, some of which have been found as far away as Mesopotamia.

Much about this civilization is still a mystery. Its writing, found on more than 4,000 small seals, has never been deciphered, so we can't read their own words. Around 1900 BCE, the cities declined. Historians think climate change, shifting rivers, and failing trade may have played a part.

LOOK CLOSER · WHAT EVIDENCE CAN AND CAN'T TELL US

Archaeologists found no grand palaces or royal tombs at Mohenjo-daro.

REMEMBER

1 Evidence: large public buildings, but no palaces or rich royal tombs.

2 Possible inference: power may have been shared, or rulers did not display wealth.

3 Limit: without readable writing, we can't confirm who ruled.

Answer: Artifacts suggest a well-organized society, but historians must say "may" until the script is read.

WORDS & MORE

KEY IDEA

The Indus Valley civilization built planned grid cities with drains and standardized bricks and weights. Its writing hasn't been deciphered, so much remains a mystery.

ACTIVITY · PLAN A CITY

Can you design a city as organized as Mohenjo-daro?

You need: graph paper; a pencil and ruler.

1 Draw a grid of streets running north–south and east–west.

2 Add a raised citadel with one public building.

3 Draw homes and a drain line under every street that leads away from the city.

4 Add a market and a granary.

Record: your city plan with a key and two sentences comparing it with Mohenjo-daro.

✓ REMEMBER

Indus cities were planned with grids and drains; their unread script keeps much a mystery.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.4, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Name two cities of the Indus Valley.

2. Name one sign that Indus cities were planned.

3. Why do historians know less about the Indus Valley than about Egypt?

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.5
Week 3 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.5: Hinduism, Buddhism, and the Maurya Empire

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain the main beliefs of Hinduism and Buddhism and how Ashoka spread Buddhist ideas.

Standards: C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.His.4.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.5 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.5, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.5 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

If you believed every action you took would come back to you, how would you act?

2 Learn

After the Indus cities declined, new ways of life spread across northern India, especially in the Ganges River valley. Sacred hymns called the Vedas were memorized and passed down for centuries. From these traditions grew Hinduism, one of the world's oldest religions.

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

Vedas
Ancient sacred hymns and teachings, the oldest texts of Hinduism.

karma
The idea that a person's actions decide what happens to them in the future.

reincarnation
The belief that the soul is reborn in a new body after death.

caste system
A system of social groups people were born into.

enlightenment
In Buddhism, a state of perfect understanding and freedom from suffering.

REMEMBER

Hindus believe in dharma (one's duty), karma (actions bring results), and reincarnation (the soul is reborn many times). Society was organized into a caste system of four main groups, or varnas: priests (Brahmins), rulers and warriors, merchants and farmers, and laborers. Some people were placed outside the system entirely and treated unfairly. India's constitution outlawed caste discrimination in 1950.

Around 2,500 years ago, a prince named Siddhartha Gautama gave up his wealth to understand why people suffer. After years of searching, he reached enlightenment and became known as the Buddha, the “awakened one.” He taught the Four Noble Truths: life includes suffering; suffering comes from desire; suffering can end; and the way to end it is the Eightfold Path of right thinking and right living. Buddhism welcomed people of every caste.

The Maurya Empire united most of India in the 300s BCE. Its greatest ruler, Ashoka, conquered the kingdom of Kalinga around 261 BCE in a war that killed many thousands. Horrified, Ashoka became a Buddhist. He carved edicts on stone pillars across his empire urging kindness, honesty, and respect for all religions, and he sent teachers who spread Buddhism to other lands.

WORDS & MORE

	Hinduism	Buddhism
began	grew over centuries from the Vedas	teachings of the Buddha, about 2,500 years ago
key beliefs	dharma, karma, reincarnation; many forms of the divine	Four Noble Truths; Eightfold Path; karma and rebirth
goal	moksha: release from the cycle of rebirth	nirvana: freedom from suffering
caste	society organized by caste	open to people of every caste

KEY IDEA

Hinduism teaches dharma, karma, and reincarnation. Buddhism teaches the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path. The Maurya emperor Ashoka spread Buddhist ideas of peace and kindness.

✓ REMEMBER

Hinduism and Buddhism shaped India; Ashoka spread Buddhist ideas of peace.

REMEMBER

WORDS & MORE

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.5, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What is karma?
2. Who became the Buddha?
3. Why did Ashoka become a Buddhist?

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.6
Week 3 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.6: China: The Huang He and the Shang Dynasty

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how geography shaped early China and describe the achievements of the Shang dynasty.

Standards: C3 D2.Geo.4.6-8, D2.His.1.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.6 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Oracle Bone Question.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.6, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.6 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

A river that feeds you and also floods your village every few years: would you call it a friend or an enemy?

2 Learn

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

dynasty
A series of rulers from the same family.

loess
Fine yellow soil blown by the wind.

oracle bone
A bone or shell used to ask questions of the gods and ancestors.

ancestor
A family member who lived long ago.

REMEMBER

Ancient China



China's first civilizations grew along the Huang He.

China's first civilization grew along the Huang He, or Yellow River, named for the yellow loess soil it carries. The soil was rich, but the river flooded so often and so violently that it was called “China's Sorrow.” Farmers built dikes and canals to control it. Mountains, deserts, and the sea cut China off from other early civilizations, so its culture developed largely on its own.

The Shang dynasty (about 1600–1046 BCE) is China's first dynasty with written records. Shang kings ruled from cities such as Anyang. Skilled workers cast beautiful bronze vessels for ceremonies, and farmers grew millet and raised silkworms.

Shang kings asked their ancestors and gods for advice with oracle bones. A priest carved a question, such as “Will the harvest be good?” on a turtle shell or ox bone, then touched it with a hot rod until it cracked. The cracks were read as the answer. These carvings are the oldest Chinese writing, and modern Chinese characters grew from them.

KEY IDEA

The Huang He gave China rich loess soil but deadly floods. The Shang dynasty cast bronze and wrote on oracle bones, the oldest Chinese writing.

ACTIVITY · ORACLE BONE QUESTION

How did the Shang record questions for their ancestors?

You need: a paper plate or a piece of cardboard cut like a shell; a pencil.

1 Write a yes-or-no question a Shang king might ask (harvest, weather, war, or a journey).

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

WORDS & MORE

2 Draw three pictograph characters to stand for key words.

3 Draw crack lines across the “shell.”

4 On the back, explain why the Shang kept these records.

Record: your oracle bone and explanation.

✓ REMEMBER

The Huang He shaped early China; the Shang cast bronze and wrote on oracle bones.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.6, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Why was the Huang He called “China's Sorrow”?
2. What is a dynasty?
3. What were oracle bones used for?

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.7
Week 4 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.7: Zhou, Qin, and Han: Confucius, the Great Wall, and the Silk Road

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain the Mandate of Heaven, Confucius's teachings, and the achievements of the Qin and Han dynasties.

Standards: C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Civ.6.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.7 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.7, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.7 (Parts B–E).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Should a ruler who governs badly be allowed to keep ruling? Who should decide?

2 Learn

The Zhou dynasty (1046–256 BCE) overthrew the Shang and explained why with a new idea: the Mandate of Heaven. A good ruler had heaven's blessing; floods, famine, or

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

Mandate of Heaven
The belief that heaven gave a ruler the right to rule, and could take it away from an unjust ruler.

filial piety
Respect and duty toward one's parents and elders.

Confucianism
Teachings of Confucius about respect, duty, and good government.

Silk Road
Trade routes that linked China with lands to the west.

REMEMBER

rebellion showed that a ruler had lost it, and a new dynasty could take power. This pattern of rise and fall is called the dynastic cycle.

Late in the Zhou period, China fell into wars between states. A teacher named Confucius (551–479 BCE) taught that order would return if people behaved well in their relationships: rulers should be fair, children should show filial piety, and everyone should be honest and respectful. Another thinker, Laozi, taught Daoism, living simply and in harmony with nature.

READING · PRIMARY SOURCE

From the Analects of Confucius

Sayings of Confucius (551–479 BCE), recorded by his students. Translated by James Legge (1861). Public domain.

The Master said, “He who exercises government by means of his virtue may be compared to the north polar star, which keeps its place and all the stars turn towards it.” (2.1)

The Master said, “When you know a thing, to hold that you know it; and when you do not know a thing, to allow that you do not know it; this is knowledge.” (2.17)

The Master said, “What you do not want done to yourself, do not do to others.” (15.23)

KEY IDEA

The Zhou introduced the Mandate of Heaven; Confucius taught respect, duty, and fair government; the Qin unified and standardized China; the Han invented paper and opened the Silk Road.

In 221 BCE, Qin Shi Huang united China and called himself the First Emperor. He ruled harshly but standardized writing, money, weights, and even cart axles. He linked older walls into an early Great Wall to keep out northern invaders and was buried with an army of more than 7,000 life-size clay soldiers, the Terracotta Army.

The Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE) ruled for about 400 years. Han emperors chose officials partly by testing their knowledge of Confucian ideas. The Han invented paper and

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

✓ REMEMBER

The Mandate of Heaven, Confucius, the Qin, and the Han shaped China's government and culture.

opened the Silk Road, trade routes that carried Chinese silk west and brought horses, glass, and new ideas, including Buddhism, into China.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.7, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What is the Mandate of Heaven?
2. What is filial piety?
3. Name one thing Qin Shi Huang standardized.

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

LESSON 2.8
Week 4 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 2: River Valley Civilizations

Lesson 2.8: Comparing River Valley Civilizations

TODAY'S GOAL

I can compare the first four civilizations and explain what they had in common.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- [ ] Read Lesson 2.8 in this book with your teacher.
- [ ] Do the Activity activity: Museum Exhibit Card.
- [ ] Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 2.8, Part A.
- [ ] Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 2.8 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Mesopotamia, Egypt, the Indus Valley, and China never planned together. Why did all four grow up beside rivers?

2 Learn

The world's first four civilizations each grew in a river valley: Mesopotamia on the Tigris and Euphrates, Egypt on the Nile, the Indus Valley on the Indus, and China on the Huang He. Rivers gave water, rich soil, and routes for trade.

WORDS & MORE

WORDS TO KNOW

compare
To find how things are alike.

contrast
To find how things are different.

common feature
Something many examples share.

legacy
Something handed down from the past.

REMEMBER

Farming made a food surplus, which let people take on special jobs, build cities, and form governments.

	Mesopotamia	Egypt	Indus Valley	China
river	Tigris and Euphrates	Nile	Indus	Huang He
floods	unpredictable	regular, gentle	monsoon floods	violent
government	city-states, then empires	pharaoh (theocracy)	unknown; organized cities	dynasties; Mandate of Heaven
writing	cuneiform	hieroglyphics	undeciphered script	oracle-bone characters
one legacy	written laws	pyramids	city planning	Confucian ideas

LOOK CLOSER · WRITE A COMPARISON CLAIM

How were Egypt's and China's rivers different, and why did it matter?

1. Contrast: the Nile flooded gently on a regular schedule; the Huang He flooded violently.
2. Effect: Egyptians could plan farming around the flood; Chinese farmers spent great effort on dikes.
3. Claim: both rivers fed people, but the Huang He demanded more control.

Answer: A strong comparison names a similarity or difference and explains why it matters.

KEY IDEA

All four first civilizations grew in river valleys, made food surpluses, built cities, developed governments, and created writing, but each had its own geography and legacy.

ACTIVITY · MUSEUM EXHIBIT CARD

What is each civilization's greatest legacy?

You need: four index cards; colored pencils.

1. Choose one achievement from each civilization.
2. Draw it on the front of a card.
3. On the back, write the civilization, the achievement, and why it still matters today.
4. Rank your four cards from most to least important and explain your top choice.

Record: your four cards and a sentence explaining your top choice.

✓ REMEMBER

All four first civilizations grew beside rivers; each left its own legacy.

WORDS & MORE

REMEMBER

WORDS & MORE

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 2.8, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What did all four river valley civilizations have in common?
2. Which civilization's writing has not been deciphered?
3. Whose floods were most regular and predictable?

UNIT 2 REVIEW

Unit 2 Study Guide

Use this page to get ready for the unit test. Read each big idea, then try the review pages in your workbook.

Lesson	Remember…
2.1	The Nile's flood, current, and deserts made Egypt rich, connected, and safe.
2.2	Egyptians believed the pharaoh was divine and planned for the afterlife with mummies and pyramids.
2.3	Egypt and Kush traded, fought, and shared culture; Kush later ruled Egypt and thrived at Meroë.
2.4	Indus cities were planned with grids and drains; their unread script keeps much a mystery.
2.5	Hinduism and Buddhism shaped India; Ashoka spread Buddhist ideas of peace.
2.6	The Huang He shaped early China; the Shang cast bronze and wrote on oracle bones.
2.7	The Mandate of Heaven, Confucius, the Qin, and the Han shaped China's government and culture.
2.8	All four first civilizations grew beside rivers; each left its own legacy.

Glossary

afterlife	Life after death.
Agricultural Revolution	The shift to farming.
ancestor	A family member who lived long ago.
archaeologist	A scientist who studies the past by digging up and examining artifacts and remains.
artifact	An object made or used by people in the past.
BCE / CE	“Before the Common Era” and “Common Era”: the years before and after year 1.
caste system	A system of social groups people were born into.
cataract	A stretch of rocky rapids in a river.
citadel	A fortress or raised area in a city.
city-state	A city and the farmland around it with its own government.
civilization	A complex society with cities and government.
code of law	A written set of laws.
common feature	Something many examples share.
compare	To find how things are alike.
Confucianism	Teachings of Confucius about respect, duty, and good government.
contrast	To find how things are different.
cultural diffusion	The spread of ideas.
cuneiform	Sumerian wedge-shaped writing.
delta	The flat, fan-shaped land where a river splits and flows into the sea.
domestication	Taming plants and animals so they can be raised by people.
dynasty	Rulers from one family.
empire	Many lands under one ruler.
enlightenment	In Buddhism, a state of perfect understanding and freedom from suffering.
epic	A long poem about a hero's deeds.
export	A good sent to another place to be sold.
filial piety	Respect and duty toward one's parents and elders.
hieroglyphics	Egyptian writing that used pictures and symbols.

hunter-gatherer	A person who gets food by hunting animals and gathering wild plants.
inundation	The yearly flood of the Nile.
irrigation	Bringing water to crops.
karma	Actions decide the future.
Kush	A powerful African kingdom in Nubia.
legacy	Something handed down from the past.
levee	A raised bank that keeps a river from flooding.
loess	Fine yellow soil blown by the wind.
Mandate of Heaven	Heaven's approval to rule.
Mesopotamia	Greek for “land between the rivers”; the region between the Tigris and Euphrates.
migration	Movement of people from one place to another.
monsoon	A seasonal wind that brings heavy rain.
mummy	A body preserved so it will last a long time.
Neolithic	The New Stone Age, when farming began.
nomad	A person who moves from place to place instead of living in one settlement.
Nubia	The region along the Nile south of Egypt, in today's Sudan.
oracle bone	A bone or shell used to ask questions of the gods and ancestors.
Paleolithic	The Old Stone Age, when people made stone tools and lived as hunter-gatherers.
pharaoh	Egypt's ruler, seen as a god.
polytheism	Belief in many gods.
primary source	Created at the time by a participant.
reincarnation	The belief that the soul is reborn in a new body after death.
scribe	A person trained to read and write and keep records.
secondary source	A source created later by someone studying the past.
Silk Road	Trade routes that linked China with lands to the west.
silt	Fine, rich soil carried and left behind by rivers.
social class	A group of people with similar wealth or status.
specialization	Doing one kind of job and trading for other needs.
standardized	Made the same everywhere, such as weights or bricks.

stele	A tall carved stone slab.
stylus	A pointed tool used to write on clay.
subcontinent	A large landmass that is part of a continent, such as India.
surplus	More than is needed to survive.
theocracy	A government ruled by religious leaders or a ruler seen as divine.
unify	To bring together into one.
Vedas	Ancient sacred hymns and teachings, the oldest texts of Hinduism.
ziggurat	A large stepped temple tower in a Sumerian city.

Grade 7 Social Studies

Student Textbook

A full year of Grade 7 social studies. Students read maps, weigh primary and secondary sources, build timelines, and connect geography, history, government, and economics to the people and places that shaped our world.

This Student Textbook teaches every lesson: the big idea, key vocabulary, models and examples, and a short set of practice problems to check understanding. It pairs with the Student Workbook and the Teacher Edition.

INSIDE THIS YEAR

01 Early Humans and Mesopotamia

02 River Valley Civilizations

IN THIS BOOK

- Clear lesson goals: “I can…” statements
- Key vocabulary with student-friendly definitions
- Models, examples, and Key Idea summaries
- A study guide and glossary for every unit

THE COMPLETE SET



Textbook
You are holding this book

Workbook

Teacher Edition

Each lesson has the same number in all three books, so the textbook, workbook, and teacher pages always match.